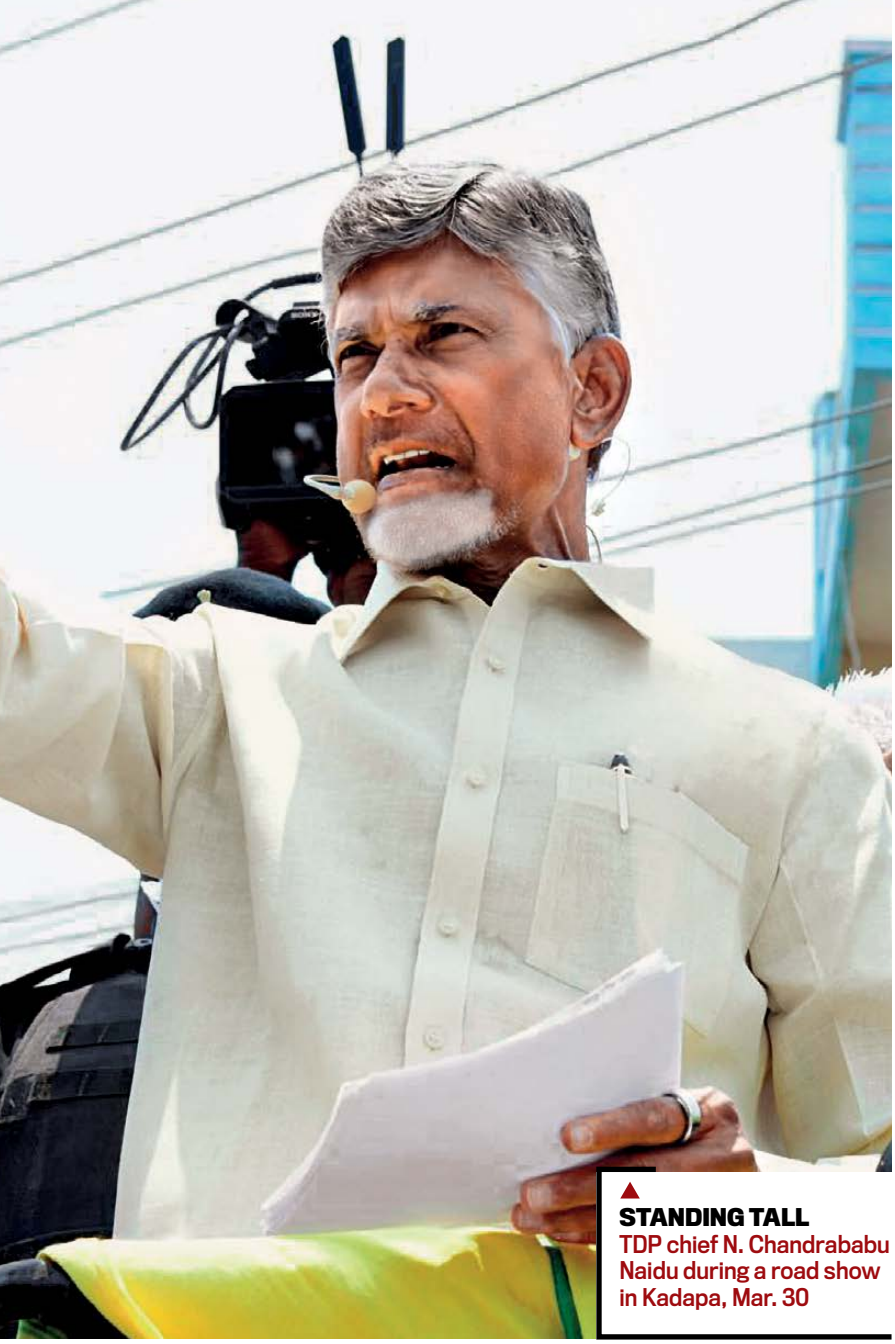


ANI

▲ **STANDING TALL**
TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu during a road show in Kadapa, Mar. 30

pounding the YSRCP's humiliation. It has been restricted to just 11 of the 175 assembly seats and four of the 25 parliamentary seats.

The remarkable comeback after that emotional 2021 walkout and having hit a political nadir in September 2023—when he was arrested by the state police in a corruption case—underscores Naidu's perseverance and political acumen. The YSRCP's near 50 per cent vote share in 2019 and Jagan's effective welfare delivery via direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes loomed large, but proved no deterrent. Undaunted, Naidu marshalled his Kamma caste vote base and forged a surprising alliance with Kalyan, even as the latter's Kapu cohort has a long history of rivalry with Kammas, and renewed ties with the BJP—forging a formidable flank to topple the YSRCP.

Naidu's family—son Lokesh, and later wife Bhuvaneswari, daughter of party founder N.T. Rama Rao—toured the state over the past two years, rallying support for the party. TDP loyalists from neighbouring states and abroad also descended to campaign and created a buzz against what the party termed an "authoritarian" regime. "Jagan's authoritarianism and disregard for constitutional bodies," notes political commentator A.M. Khan Yazdani, "proved to be his undoing."

Banking on just DBT beneficiaries also backfired for Jagan. Resorting to token social inclusion—by assigning ministries to leaders from various groups without giving them any real authority—alienated nearly all sections. The disillusionment was so severe that in Visakhapatnam parliamentary constituency, the TDP's Mathukumilli Sribharat won by a record 504,247 votes despite Jagan's ambitious plan of turning the port city into the state's administrative capital. For Jagan, despite cornering a nearly 40 per cent vote share, the prospects of keeping the YSRCP rank and file together will be a tall order.

Meanwhile, with a 16-seat tally, the TDP has emerged as the second largest constituent of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) at the Centre. This comes as a boon for Naidu, as he takes over the reins of a cash-strapped state. Andhra Pradesh faces a massive Rs 13.5 lakh crore debt burden. Revitalising the state's finances is a priority if Naidu wants to revive his Amaravati megapolis project and deliver on the 'Super Six' guarantees, including two million new jobs and an array of populist freebies. Driving a hard bargain, he is demanding Special Category Status for the state to get central grants on priority. Promised during the state's bifurcation in 2014, it was later denied by the Modi regime, forcing Naidu to quit the NDA in 2018.

Andhra's longest-serving chief minister, Naidu is an old hand at political machinations that go on in New Delhi, having played a key role in cobbling together coalitions to form the two United Front governments (1996-98) and then serving as the NDA convenor under former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee. The coming days will test his perseverance and acumen to the hilt. ■